Documentation and Training Built From the Task

How I write documentation and design training for the people who install, run, and maintain complex software and hardware.

> Every procedure and every objective traces to a task. Every review and every test checks that task. That is how the content stays tied to the job.

A — ANALYZE

Start with the job. Work with engineers, subject-matter experts, and installers to list the tasks people perform and who performs them. Find the steps that differ from the standard: they need the clearest procedures and the most practice.

D — DESIGN

Write each procedure and each objective from a task. Choose the deliverable the task calls for - a guide, a Method of Procedure, a reference table, a course, or a job aid - and build it to the style guide and templates.

D — DEVELOP

Build what the task needs: user and administrator guides, installation guides and Methods of Procedure (MOPs), troubleshooting manuals, instructor materials, hands-on labs and lab guides, web-based courses, and job aids.

I — IMPLEMENT

Release it where the work is. Documentation goes through engineering technical review and sign-off and through peer review. Training is delivered instructor-led, hands-on, virtually, and on the web, and other instructors are prepared so delivery is the same everywhere.

E — EVALUATE

Check it on the task. Track content defects and customer feedback, review an item analysis for every test, survey every course, and change the content based on what the data shows.

FROM TASK TO PROCEDURE TO TEST

TASK
What the installer does on the job: remove and replace a unit in working equipment.

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PROCEDURE
Written from that task: the steps in order, reviewed and signed off by engineering.

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OBJECTIVE
Written from that procedure: remove and replace the unit safely and correctly.

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TEST
Checked on that task: the installer performs the replacement to the procedure, hands-on.

Illustrative example. The structure reflects how the work was built; the content shown is generic.

WHERE I HAVE APPLIED IT

- User and administrator guides
- Installation guides and MOPs
- Troubleshooting manuals
- Installation training for field technicians
- Hands-on and instructor-led training
- Web-based courses
- Job aids
- Recurring certification training